

"Branded" Mobiles

Hummer launched a range of phones a while ago, and now Levi's has announced a mobile phone. Designed by Mode-Labs and built of steel, it will match the clothier's apparel range. Specs remain secret, but with the phone will be offered a chain to hook it up with, of course, jeans.



Baby Monitor Picks Up Unlikely Signal

In the past, people have gotten hold of radio stations and broadcasts from neighbours' baby monitors. Now, recently, a Palestine mom got quite a shock when her baby monitor started picking up broadcasts from NASA's International Space Station. Hawking's "baby universes"?



Escape

HEROINWARE

Gaming Now Officially A Disease!

The shrinks at The American Medical Association are moving to officially recognise "Internet/video gaming addiction" as a disorder. What this means is that lawyers will, in the future, attempt to blame "gory video games" for crimes ranging from eve-teasing to mass murder, and use the medically-recognised disorder to bolster their defences. The pharmaceutical companies must be smacking their lips right now, what with a new product line and another set of different coloured pills to pump into unsuspecting bodies.

When it comes to complaints, the online multiplayer game *EverQuest* tops the charts, with relatives of gamers complaining that playing that game is far too addictive to be safe among teenagers. Some people are

even referring to it as "EverCrack"... Disgruntled spouses of *EverQuest* players have actually set up a group to voice their concerns and share their experiences! The description of their group says, "EverQuest Widows is a forum for partners, family, and friends of people who play *EverQuest* compulsively. We turn to each other because it's no fun talking to the back of someone's head while they're retrieving their corpse or 'telling' with their guild-mates as you speak." In paranoid America, there have been centres set up to "treat" gamers with video game addiction. Sites like On-Line Gamers Anonymous (www.olganonboard.org) are solely dedicated to providing help to gamers who cannot prioritise their daily responsibilities vis-à-vis their game playing

needs.

However, Sony Online Entertainment, the company behind *EverQuest*, denies any wrongdoing, stating: "I guess our standpoint is the same as all kinds of products—you have to be responsible in using it. You don't see disclaimers when you get in a car saying 'Don't run over people.' People have to exhibit their own good sense, and if they have kids, they need to pay attention to what they're doing."

What is still baffling us is: is it possible to become completely dependent on a game? And if so, exactly what are the symptoms of sudden video game withdrawal?

What can we say... gamers will be gamers, Americans will be Americans, and shrinks will be shrinks. That's about it.

Whatever Happened To...

Dialpad.com

We dug up an article on the Net dating back to July 2000, which begins thus: "The old adage goes 'There ain't no such thing as a free lunch.' Long distant phone carriers may be wishing the same thing could be said about long distance phone calls. Menlo Park-based Dialpad.com offers free long distance phone calls to any telephone number in the United States, via your computer and the Internet."

Yes, back in 2000, speaking to someone using the Internet (!) was a brand new thing. Dialpad only let you call numbers in the United States, but from anywhere, and people flocked to the site in droves to register and call, call, call, even just for the fun of it. (There was Net2Phone back then as well, but they charged.)

And then VoIP took off in a big way. You know the rest. IMs began integrating voice chat. Skype happened, including cheap calls to phones. Today, type anything VoIP-related into Google and you'll see ads upon ads upon ads: "Worldwide Internet Calls. Low Rates. Sign Up Today." "Internet Phone Calls at Low Rates. Inexpensive, High-Quality Service." The companies are running out of sensible domain names.

We never noticed: Yahoo! acquired the company in 2005. Now, dialpad.com redirects to Yahoo! Voice, Web 2.0-themed and all. Few remember Dialpad.

Win! My Desktop

Last month's winner is **G Arun Bala**, Kalavakkam

How he did it:

"I got inspired for this design from Digit 6th anniversary issue's CD/DVD interface. Unlike others using some freebie tools' themes, widgets and object docks built by third party while earning credit themselves for the work of mere application of tools, the passion for making a desktop became a near reality when I saw your CD/DVD interface. The cool Web 2.0 graphics with Vista look made a great impact. Rather customising and using a desktop, why not create one—which in my perception holds high, and thus I designed this from scratch."

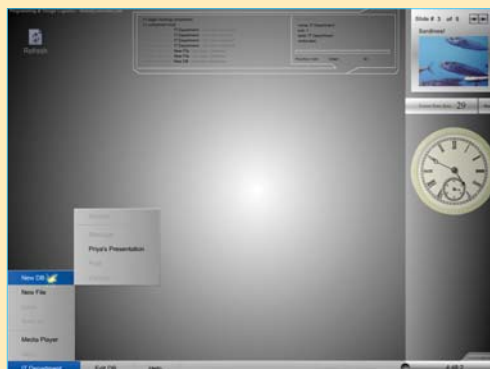
Participate in this contest and win next month

Software Architecture

by Frank Buschmann

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Send in your Desktop with a description of how you made it to mydesktop@thinkdigit.com with the subject "My Desktop", and tell us your postal address, too.